

## Fills

Fills are short and simple rhythmic passages played by musicians to “fill in” or “fill up” the space between phrases. Most fills are typical of a certain genre. Drummers may use fills as a chance to perform a mini-solo, but for the most part fills are not especially notable. This quality distinguishes them from riffs, which tend to be memorable, even unforgettable, hallmarks of a particular tune.

### ▽ Fill

In this example of a fill, a bass player fills two measures between phrases with a short, flashy transitional move from C major to F major, and then back again.

The musical score shows three staves: Vocals, Piano, and Electric Bass. The Vocals staff has the lyrics "Yeah, hon - ey. Oh, ba - by...". The Piano staff has a simple harmonic accompaniment. The Electric Bass staff features a two-measure fill highlighted in purple, which is a short, flashy transitional move from C major to F major, and then back again. An arrow points to this fill with the text "Electric bass solo provides a two-measure fill".

### REAL WORLD

#### Dizzy Gillespie (1917–1993)

Flashy, impressive breaks on solo trumpet were a hallmark of Dizzy Gillespie's trademark bebop style. His style featured fast tempi, amazing virtuosity, and breathtaking improvised instrumental solos by him and his bandmates.



## Vamps

A vamp is a simple two-, four-, or eight-measure harmonic pattern (even a single chord) played in the same rhythm over and over until a cue. “Vamp till ready” is a musical command in musical theater scores. Vamps allow for in-the-moment improvisations in live performances of rock or blues music.

The musical score shows a classic vamp in 4/4 time. The treble staff has a repeated C minor chord (C3, E3, G3) over a descending bass line (C4, B3, A3, G3). The bass staff has a repeated C minor chord (C3, E3, G3) over a descending bass line (C4, B3, A3, G3). The vamp is repeated for two measures.

### △ Classic vamp

This repeated C minor chord over a descending bass line, from scale degree 1 to scale degree 5 or *sol*, is typical of a vamp.